Course design overview · Stages 1 and 2

Policy & Strategy Lab

A 20-day intensive in structured problem-solving for Indian public policy



Twenty teaching days. Filled dots mark the four feedback gates; the last is the defence.

Draft for review · 10 November 2026

One real problem, from a vague concern to a defended recommendation

20

teaching days, Monday to Friday over four weeks

40

live hours, two a day, mostly spent producing work

1

case per participant, carried from start to finish

4

feedback gates before the final defence

Unlike academic policy courses, **it ends in a decision and an implementation plan, not an essay.** Unlike consulting bootcamps, **it treats the state as institutions with divided jurisdiction, contested goals and frontline discretion, not as a firm.**

The promise is calibrated: a capable junior analyst on a scoped problem, not a consultant or a sector expert.

Three gaps the programme exists to close

1

Description to decision

Graduates can describe and critique a policy problem but struggle to advise someone who must act: what to do, at what cost, and how anyone would know it worked.

2

Consulting transfer

Consulting tools teach structure but treat the client as a firm. Public problems have contested goals, divided jurisdiction, fixed budgets and frontline discretion.

3

Implementation

Indian policy debate often stops at design. Much failure happens further down the delivery chain, where a capable centre cannot reliably direct its field agencies.

The premise that these skills are under-taught is tested through a paired entry and exit diagnostic, not assumed.

Seven principles govern every design decision

1 Frameworks are instruments of reasoning

Each tool is taught by the question it answers, its inputs, its output and its misuses.

2 One problem, carried all the way

Every workbook builds part of the final report. Nothing is done once and thrown away.

3 An early answer, tested hard

A working answer is sealed on Day 3. The rest of the programme tries to break it.

4 Decisions, not descriptions

Every case names a decision-making role and the decision it faces.

5 The state is not a firm

Every recommendation is tested for jurisdiction, money and frontline delivery.

6 Make, then challenge, then revise

Every session produces an artefact; every week includes structured peer challenge.

7 Distribution is an analytical test

Who benefits, who pays and who is excluded have their own rows in the templates.

01

How the programme is built

One method, four weeks, one case carried from start to finish

Consulting method diagnoses; policy analysis chooses

The Lab uses each where it is strongest: the seven steps govern Weeks 1 to 3, the eightfold path governs Week 4.

McKinsey seven steps

Six of seven steps build the diagnosis

1. Define the problem
2. Disaggregate the issues
3. Prioritise
4. Build a workplan
5. Conduct analyses
6. Synthesise findings
7. Communicate

Bardach's eightfold path

Six of eight steps build and choose between options

1. Define the problem
2. Assemble some evidence
3. Construct the alternatives
4. Select the criteria
5. Project the outcomes
6. Confront the trade-offs
7. Decide
8. Tell your story

Four weeks, one case, carried all the way

Week 1

Define and structure

What exactly is the problem, and for whom?

Output

Problem diagnostic

Gate 1 · Day 5

Week 2

Situate and prioritise

Who can act, with what money, and what should we test?

Output

Research plan

Gate 2 · Day 10

Week 3

Investigate and synthesise

What does the published evidence establish?

Output

Diagnostic memo

Gate 3 · Day 15

Week 4

Decide, deliver, defend

What should be done, by whom, and how will we know?

Output

Deck and defence

Gate 4 · Day 19; panel Day 20



The 20-day architecture: Weeks 1 and 2

Day	Theme	Anchor tool	Participant output
1	Problems, clients and decisions	Sorting problem, symptom, cause and solution	Cases sorted; decision-maker named
2	Defining the problem	Problem Definition Canvas	Problem statement; Case Approval Form
3	Structuring	Issue tree (MECE); sealed working answer	Issue tree; sealed answer
4	Causes · Thursday challenge	Problem tree	Causal diagnosis
5	Systems and scope lock · Gate 1	Causal loop diagram	Problem diagnostic
6	Jurisdiction, money and delivery	Delivery chain map	Delivery chain and funding map
7	Actors and political economy	Power-interest map with absent voices	Stakeholder and incentive matrix
8	Prioritising issues	Pruning matrix	Pruned tree with rationale
9	Hypotheses · Thursday challenge	Hypothesis register	Register with disconfirming tests
10	Workplan · Gate 2	Workplan matrix	Research plan; evidence register

The 20-day architecture: Weeks 3 and 4

Day	Theme	Anchor tool	Participant output
11	Finding and judging evidence · Studio	Source reliability assessment	Evidence register entries
12	Quantitative analysis · Studio	Disaggregation in a spreadsheet	Three charts with interpretation
13	Qualitative and comparative · Studio	Comparative case matrix	Comparative matrix; thematic notes
14	Testing · Thursday challenge	Hypothesis testing matrix	Verdict on each hypothesis
15	Synthesis · Gate 3	Pyramid Principle with SCQA	Two-page diagnostic memo
16	Generating options	How Might We with a journey map	Three or more distinct options
17	Choosing	Options appraisal matrix	Appraisal and recommendation
18	Delivery design	Theory of change	Implementation plan
19	Measurement and pitch · Gate 4	Indicator framework	Indicators; draft deck
20	Defence	Panel presentation	Presentation; report due 72 hours later

Every case must pass three India-specific reality tests

1

Jurisdiction

Who has the authority to act?

Participants learn

Seventh Schedule lists; 73rd and 74th Amendments; legislative authority, administrative control and funding as separate powers.

The test fails when

the recommendation is addressed to a body that cannot act on it.

2

Money

Where does the funding come from?

Participants learn

Budget heads; central sector and centrally sponsored schemes; Union and state cost sharing; Finance Commission transfers.

The test fails when

nobody can say which budget line would pay for it.

3

Frontline

What will the people who deliver it do?

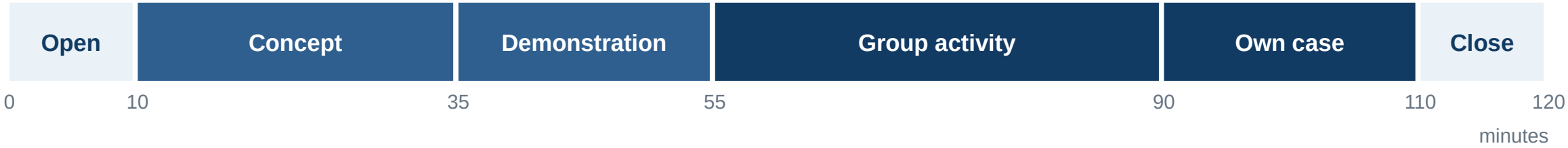
Participants learn

The delivery chain from ministry to frontline worker; caseloads, discretion and incentives.

The test fails when

the plan assumes frontline workers will simply comply.

Every session is built for making, not listening



Frame and close · 20 minutes

An opening problem or retrieval question; a debrief and an exit task.

Teach · 45 minutes

One concept, then a demonstration of the anchor tool on the instructor's spine case.

Make · 55 minutes

A group activity on a common case, then each participant applies the tool to their own case.

The weekly rhythm

Monday to Wednesday

Learn and apply

Thursday

Challenge: simulation, hypothesis battle or red team

Friday

Consolidate: gate submission and pod review

Theory enters as a question about the participant's own case

Day	Thinker	The question it puts to the participant's case
1	Rittel and Webber	Whose definition of the problem are you adopting, and what would count as solved?
2	Sen	Are you measuring access to a resource, or what people can actually do with it?
6	Pritchett; Kapur	At which link in the delivery chain does intent at the top stop becoming action?
7	Ostrom; Lipsky	Which rules actually govern behaviour, and what will frontline workers really do?
8	Simon	What is good enough to investigate, and what will you knowingly leave out?
16	Hall	Are you adjusting settings, changing instruments or changing goals?
17	Moore; Lindblom	Does the option create public value, win support and have the capacity behind it?
19	Kingdon	Is there a policy window for this recommendation, and which stream is missing?

02

What participants learn, and how we know

Ten outcomes, fifty competencies and one set of criteria used everywhere

Ten outcomes, each anchored in a domain of competence

A

Problem framing

Write a decision-focused problem statement

B

Structuring

Build and prune a MECE issue tree

C

Causes and systems

Separate symptoms from causes; show feedback

D

Institutions

Map jurisdiction, money, delivery and actors

E

Evidence

Find, judge and triangulate published evidence

F

Hypotheses

Test falsifiable hypotheses against rivals

G

Design and appraisal

Appraise three distinct options explicitly

H

Execution

Plan owners, risks, indicators and a theory of change

I

Communication

Write top-down; present and defend

J

Judgement

Name limits, trade-offs and uncertainty

Three levels describe every domain; Working is the standard

Example: Domain A, problem framing

Foundational

The canvas is complete, but the statement stays broad or contains a cause or solution. The decision-maker is "the government" in general.

Working

Completion standard

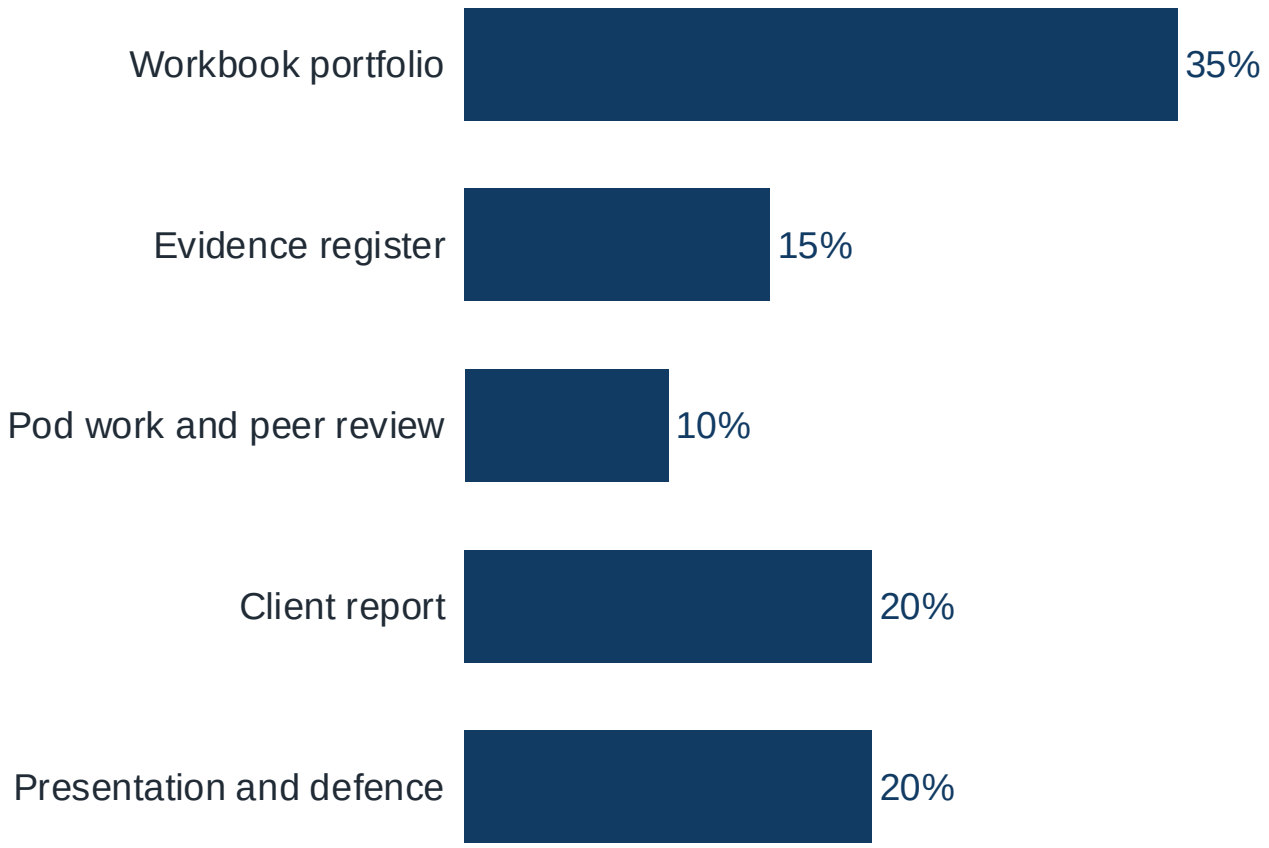
The statement is specific, free of solutions and bounded. It names a role with authority and a real decision. Success is a change in people's conditions.

Advanced

Also anticipates how others would frame the problem, explains why this framing serves the decision, and revises it when evidence requires.

The completion threshold itself is deferred to Stage 8.

Assessment keeps individual work individual



95% of marks are individual. The only collective mark is the 5 per cent pod synthesis slide on Day 20.

4 gates give detailed feedback. Proposed: gates carry no marks; the portfolio is marked once, with credit for revision.

5 feedback headings at every gate: strongest element, critical weakness, missing dimension, required revision, next task.

The capstone is the case, finished

1. **Client report**
   3,500 to 4,500 words, written to the named decision-maker, with annexes

2. **Full deck**
   10 to 12 slides, submitted rather than presented in full

3. **Presentation**
   5 slides in 6 minutes, recommendation in the first minute

4. **Individual defence**
   6 minutes of questions on evidence, assumptions and feasibility

5. **Reflection**
   500 words that open the sealed Day 3 answer and explain what changed

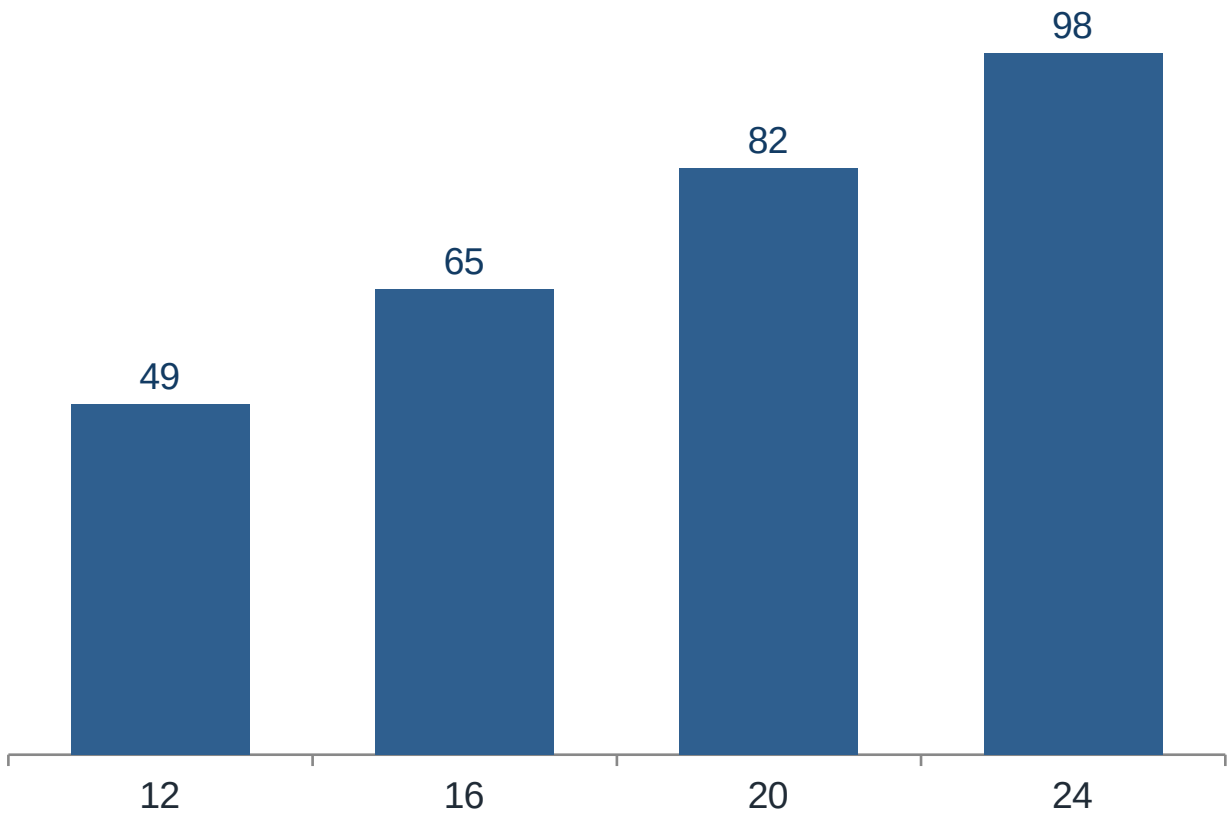
Timeline

Day 19
Gate 4: draft deck

Day 20
Presentation, defence and pod synthesis slide

Day 20 + 72 hours
Client report and reflection due

One instructor can give real feedback to about sixteen participants



Feedback and grading hours by cohort size (participants)

About 4 hours

of feedback per participant across the programme.

About 9

presentations fit in a two-hour Day 20. Sixteen need two panels or a longer session.

Recommendation

cap the first cohort at 16; add a teaching assistant above that.

Six decisions are recorded; six still shape the next stages

Recorded

Audience — Provisional
Final-year UG, PG and early-career

One anchor tool per day — Provisional
Review when Stage 4 is presented

Named client role — Provisional
A role, never contacted

Completion standard — Deferred
To be set in Stage 8

Primary research — Approved
None; published evidence only

Capstone format — Approved
Report, pitch, defence, reflection

Open

- **Cohort size**
  Recommended 12 to 16
- **Delivery mode**
  Online, in person or hybrid
- **Spine case**
  Waste segregation or foundational literacy
- **Pod composition**
  Recommended: same state, different problems
- **Gate mechanics**
  Recommended: feedback only, marked at the end
- **Workbooks**
  Recommended: ten, aligned to the gates

Next: Stage 3 builds the framework library

1. **Research each tool at its source**

   Original books, papers and firm publications, not summaries.

2. **Verify who created it**

   Originated, developed, popularised or simply used: each tool gets an honest attribution.

3. **Write a one-page tool card**

   Question, inputs, output, steps, Indian example, misuses, limits and place in the seven steps.

4. **Widen the search**

   PwC, KPMG, Accenture, government delivery units and development agencies.

5. **Deliver as Word, PDF and slides**

   A library document and a tool-card deck in this visual style.